Khrushchev was not going to start a nuclear war, but what he had in mind was extremely dangerous nuclear brinkmanship. And yet it looked like the only solution to the two foreign policy imperatives facing him—the need to support Cuba's newfound communism and overcome American superiority in nuclear missiles. Khrushchev had presented himself publicly as the defender of world communism and leader of a country that was outdoing the Americans in missile technology. Now he had to deliver.